

Site Selection

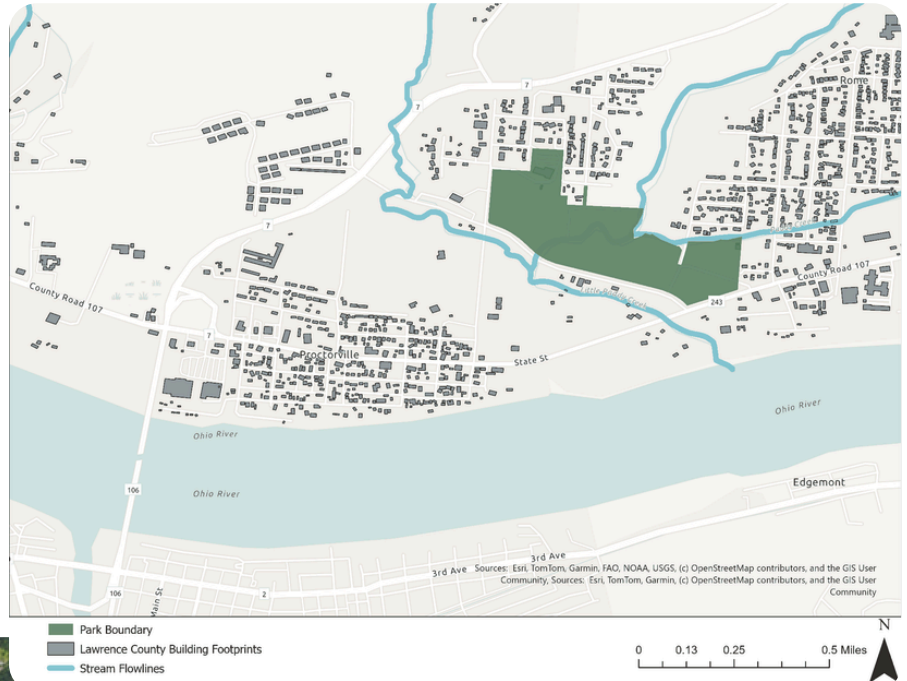
Proctor Landing Park was selected as the capstone site through the studio context in part because of its value to the School of Planning and its broader relevance as a public landscape in Lawrence County, Ohio. Positioned between Proctorville and Rome within an active river corridor, the site offers a strong test case for integrated work across planning, landscape performance, public health, and flood-resilient design.



Although the site was not self-selected, it quickly proved to be a productive project ground. Its size, local visibility, and relationship to the Ohio River, Paddy Creek, and surrounding communities make it more than leftover open land. The design challenge is not to invent a park from nothing, but to transform an underperforming landscape into one that works harder environmentally, socially, and experientially.

Regional and Community Context

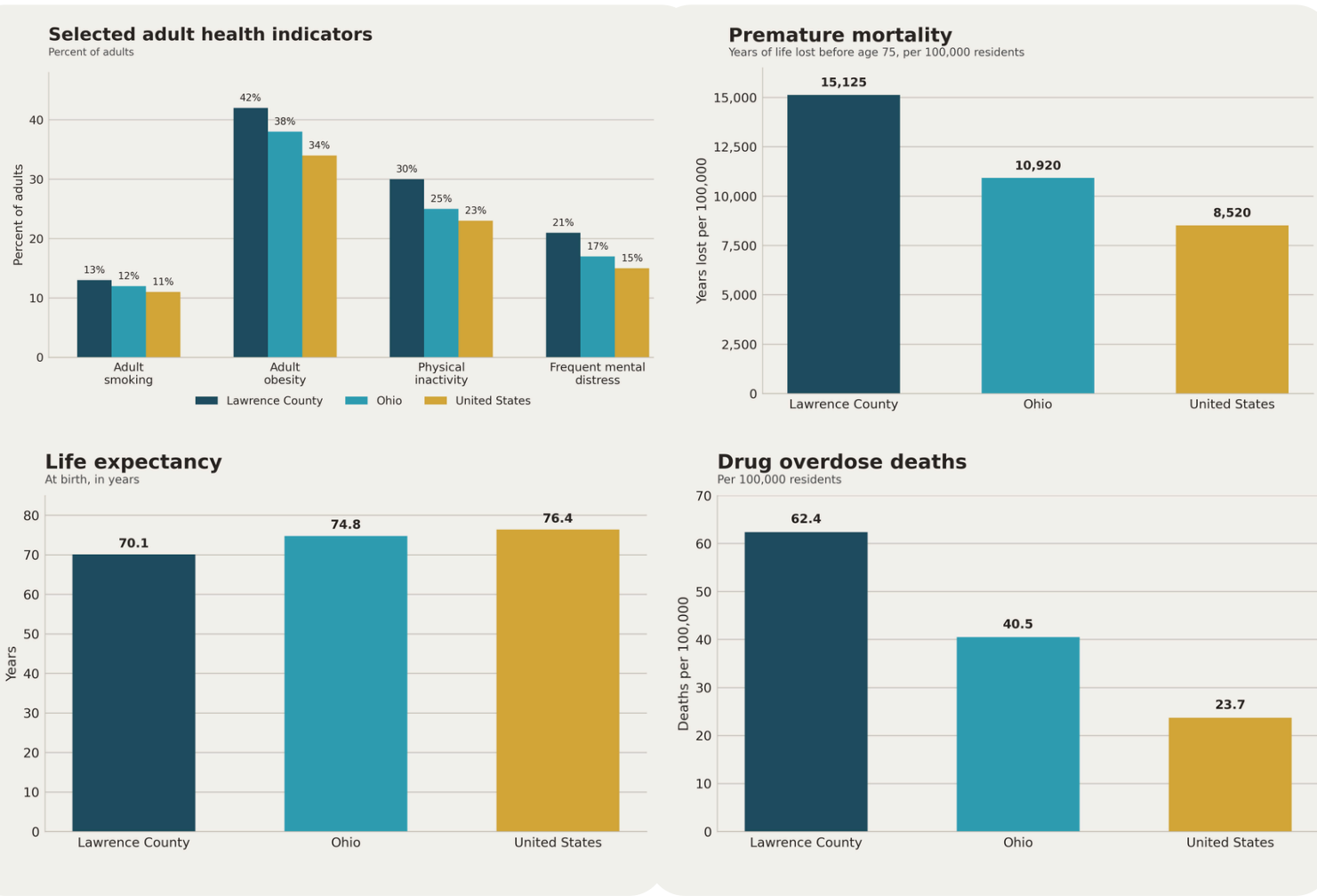
Proctor Landing Park lies within a larger river corridor landscape shaped by the Ohio River and its tributary systems. The site sits near the edge of Proctorville and Rome with close relationships to Huntington, West Virginia, surrounding residential areas, and the broader Appalachian Ohio context. This location matters because the park is not only a local amenity site. It is part of a regional hydrologic and social system. The surrounding geography reinforces both opportunity and constraint. The Ohio River provides scenic identity and ecological value, while local roads, neighborhoods, and adjacent civic resources create the potential for a strong everyday public landscape.



Lawrence County's demographic and health conditions make that landscape role more urgent. This is not a site for luxury spectacle. It is a practical community landscape that must deliver everyday value. Proctorville and Rome are small river communities shaped by floodplain terrain, limited room for error, and the need for durable public space. The park therefore has to operate as a legible, welcoming, and flexible resource across seasons and hydrologic conditions.

Public Health Risk Context

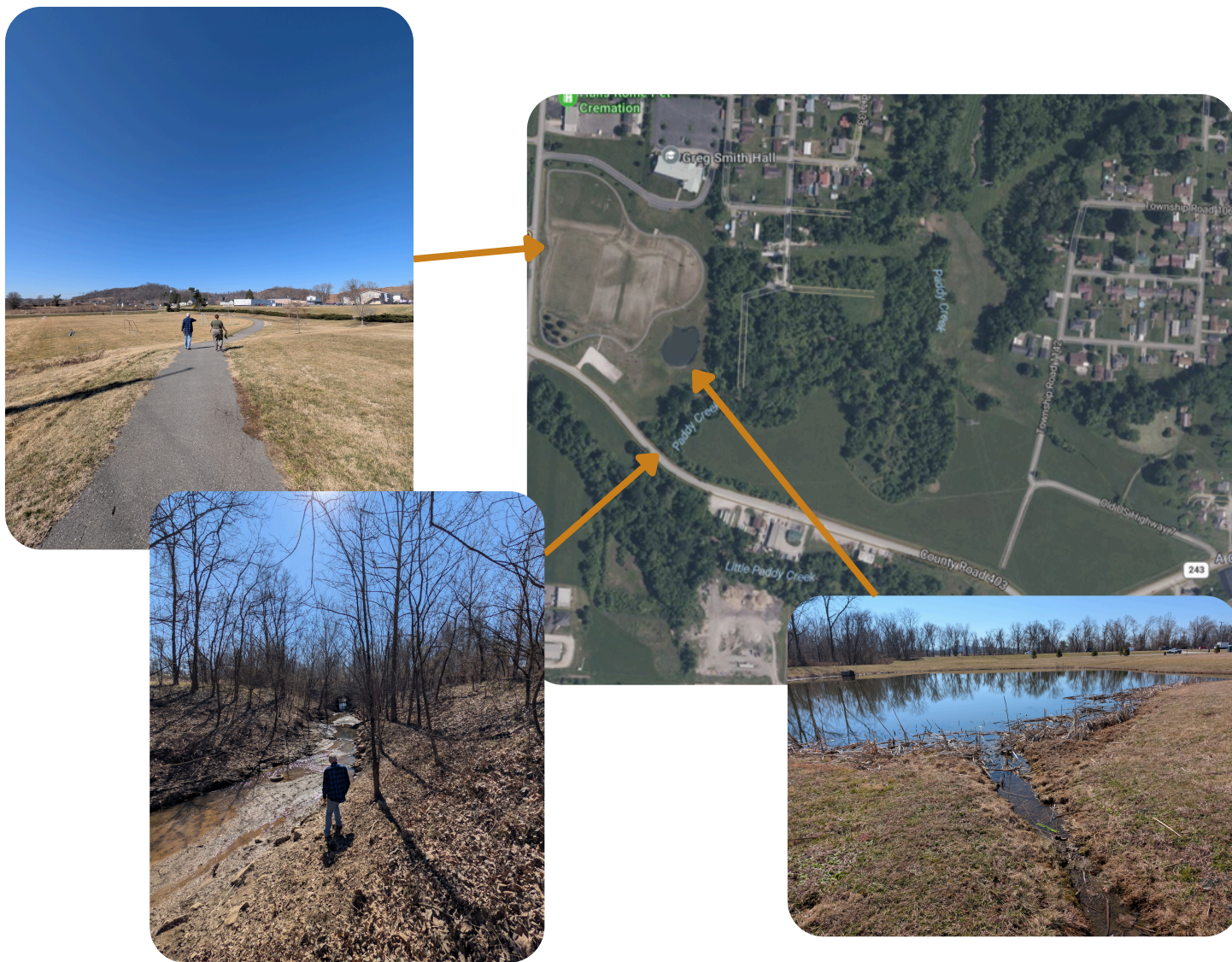
Lawrence County faces a clear public health burden shaped by chronic disease, substance use, mental health stress, and lower life expectancy than state and national benchmarks. Obesity, smoking, physical inactivity, overdose mortality, and premature mortality all point to a community condition in which preventable health risk is not abstract. It is measurable, persistent, and tied to everyday environments.



These conditions matter to the project because they change the role of the park. In this context, Proctor Landing Park is not simply recreation space. It is a potential piece of low-barrier public health infrastructure. Walkable circulation, shade, nature access, informal activity, and restorative open space can support daily movement and mental well-being driven by social and ecological immersion in a community facing elevated health risk.

Local Site Context and Access Gaps

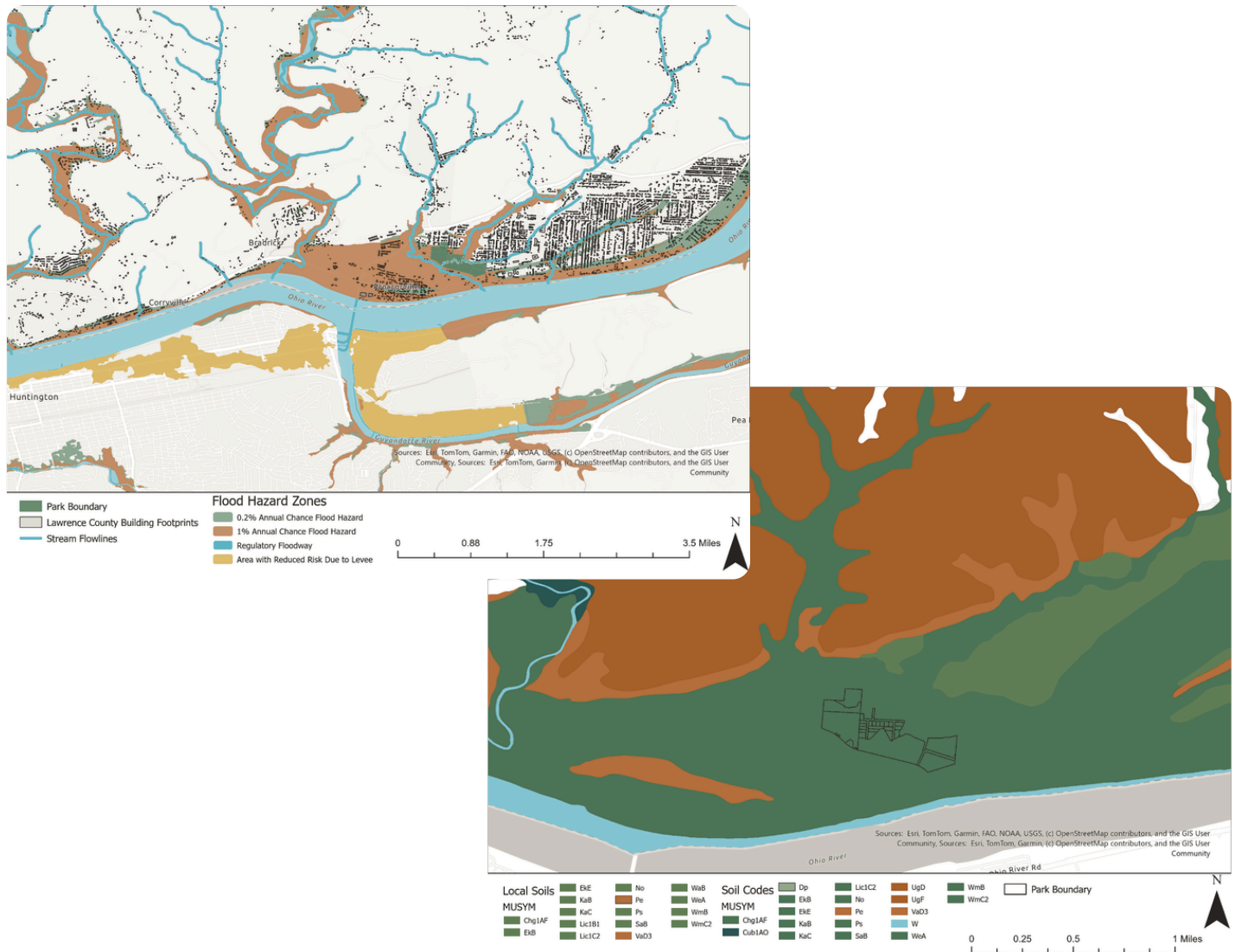
At the local scale, Proctor Landing Park is defined by its proximity to the Ohio River, its relationship to nearby recreation assets, and its lack of strong internal or external connections. While the site sits within reach of regional trails, riverfront communities, and nearby recreation destinations, those relationships are weak on the ground. Direct pedestrian and trail connections are limited, making the park feel more isolated than its location would suggest. Rather than functioning as part of a connected recreation system, the site currently reads as a remote and under-linked open landscape.



The site itself is broad, open, and relatively barren outside a few existing uses. A short trail loop at the west end provides limited local access, while sports fields occupy part of the site but are compromised by recurring flooding and inconsistent usability. Large open areas lack spatial definition, shade, and a strong destination quality. Together, these conditions make the site feel underperforming despite its size and river adjacency. The design opportunity is therefore not simply to add amenities, but to transform a disconnected and flood-affected landscape into one that feels accessible, purposeful, and reliable for everyday use.

Floodplain, Hydrology, and Soils

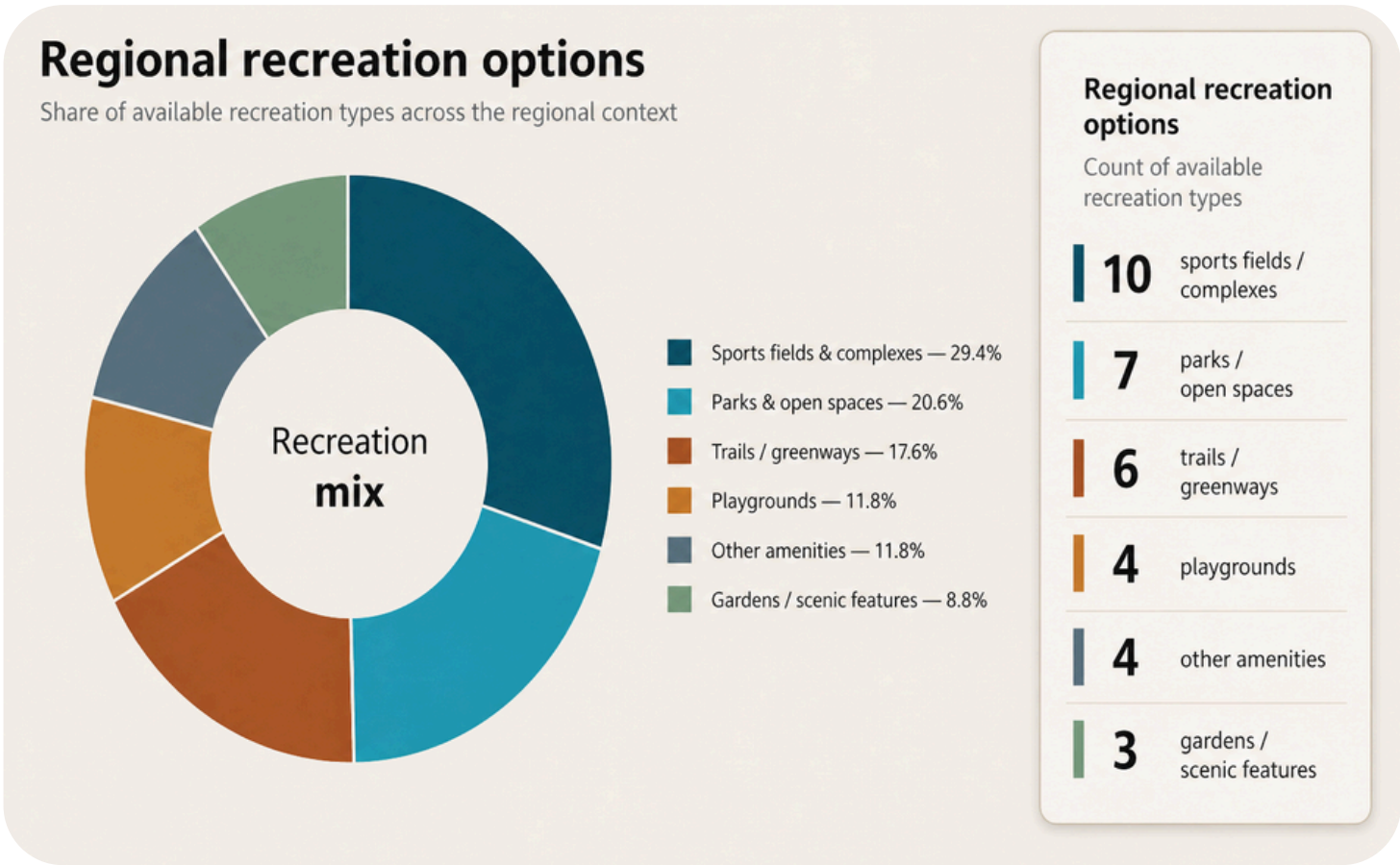
The site occupies an active floodplain shaped by the Ohio River, Symmes Creek backwater, and Paddy Creek, which runs directly through the park. Much of the site lies within the 1 percent annual chance floodplain, with smaller higher areas in the 0.2 percent or 500 year flood zone. Flooding is typically shallow, slow-draining, and tied to ponding, sediment deposition, and reduced reliability after storm events. Water is not a background condition here. It is one of the site's primary design drivers.



Soils reinforce that condition. The site sits within the alluvial floodplain of the Ohio River Valley and is dominated by silt loam to silty clay loam soils formed through repeated flooding. These soils are fertile but prone to compaction, slow drainage, seasonal saturation, and variable bearing capacity, with added erosion risk along stream banks and disturbed slopes. Together, these conditions limit heavier permanent construction in low areas and support a more flood-tolerant strategy built around wetlands, riparian planting, and softer ground-responsive systems.

Recreational Diversity Gap

Within a 30-minute travel radius of the site, the region contains a meaningful number of recreation assets, including parks, trails, playgrounds, sports venues, and other community amenities. On paper, that looks substantial. In practice, the system is heavily weighted toward organized sports, while options for everyday walking, passive recreation, and low-barrier daily movement are more limited. Trail infrastructure is also fragmented, with many routes functioning as isolated segments rather than a connected network.



That gap matters at Proctor Landing Park. Many higher-amenity recreation destinations are concentrated farther west toward Huntington and Barboursville, often requiring car access from Proctorville and Rome. Locally, the issue is not a total absence of recreation, but a lack of connected, reliable, and multi-use spaces that support daily use across ages, abilities, and seasons. This positions the park as an opportunity to add walkable access, diversified programming, and flood-adaptive recreation within an underserved riverfront context.

SWOT and Opportunity Synthesis

The site's strongest assets are its size, visibility, river-adjacent setting, and capacity to support multiple forms of recreation and ecological function within one landscape. Its greatest weaknesses are recurring flooding, weak internal connections, limited identity, and a lack of reliable, diverse everyday-use spaces. These conditions reinforce the central challenge of the project: transforming an underperforming open landscape into a park that works socially, ecologically, and experientially.

SWOT Analysis

Site conditions and strategic directions for Proctor Landing Park

 Strengths • Large open site area • Strong Ohio River corridor presence • Existing ecological base • High visibility as a civic landscape • Capacity for multiple new programs	 Weaknesses • Recurring flooding • Low-lying, slow-draining ground • Weak internal and external connections • Limited existing amenities • Lack of identity • Barren open-field character • Limited shade
 Opportunities • Visible stormwater systems • Continuous movement loop • Riparian and wetland restoration • Diverse everyday-use recreation • Program anchors and social nodes • Increased shade	 Threats • More intense rain events • Erosion • Floodplain regulation • Underinvestment • Maintenance burden • Conflict between active uses and sensitive ecological areas
 Key opportunity Organize the site as linked systems rather than isolated amenities so movement, ecology, and public life reinforce one another.	
 Strategic directions Water as ecological infrastructure Movement as health infrastructure Draw as social infrastructure	

The clearest opportunity is to organize the site around a set of linked systems rather than isolated amenities. Restored wetland and riparian areas can work with flood conditions, circulation can improve daily access and site legibility, and new destinations can create stronger social draw across the park. The goal is not simply to fill the site with program, but to structure it so movement, ecology, and public life reinforce one another.